

CHENNAI • Thursday, August 13, 2026



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THE HINDU



Sail past Chennai's coastline with the Royal Madras Yacht Club as your start point **P4**

SURIYA'S RETURN TO ROMANCE **P6**



A look back in time (Clockwise from left) Actor Sivaji Ganesan addresses a 1958 rally protesting a cut in raw film imports. Seated on stage are SS Rajendran, MG Ramachandran, and Gemini Ganesan; Boney M performs in Chennai on November 19, 1997; an Indo-Russian film unit at Mamallapuram; Satyajit Ray, AV Meiyappan and B Nagi Reddi at the Tagore Centenary celebrations at Woodlands, Madras, on May 9, 1961. THE HINDU ARCHIVES



As Chennai turns 387, The Hindu's Made of Chennai, celebrates its culture and takes over its streets with an August full of heritage, food, music, sport and more



routes, ending victoriously with a breakfast from Murugan Idli. There will also be a 1k saree run/walk at the Besant Nagar beach.

The month-long celebrations culminate in the Food and Music Festival on August 29, bringing together food, live music and family-friendly entertainment. The festival will feature a wide range of food brands like Ciclo Café, Oye Hoya, Batter Ice Cream, Ricky's Cookies and Bien Butter, among many others.



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There will also be a giant game zone with interactive games designed for families, children and groups. "Every year, we curate the food and music festival based on what the current trends are like. It depends on the customer's preferences. This year we have seen that smash burgers and Milo are trending so we're planning things around that," says Shabman Banu, food curator, adding that the usual hits like Gopaul Bun Butter, Kuhiraman Ice Cream, and the unusual delicacies like paaya biryani, and Mannady nonbu kanji will be present.

There will also be a recreation of the Mannady Ramzan street food experience at the festival. Over the next few weeks, Chennai's streets, beaches, old buildings and public spaces will fill with people revisiting familiar memories and making new ones. This is after all, less a date on the calendar, and more an excuse to spend a time romanticising the city.

To register for events by Made of Chennai, log on to newsth.live/MOC2026ED.

Made of Chennai events

■ Reader engagement contests: August 11 onwards (Trivia: August 11 to 20; photo quiz August 21 to September 10)

■ Archival exhibition: from August 14

■ Moonlight cinema: August 16

■ Made of Chennai run and saree run: August 23

■ Royapuram railway station heritage walk: August 23

■ Food and Music Festival: August 29



Check out the detailed list of events by scanning the QR code to register and participate in The Hindu's Made of Chennai.

The Madras mosaic

Sangita Rajan
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At a centenary celebration of poet and freedom fighter Rabindranath Tagore, hosted at the iconic Woodlands Hotel in 1961, an unusual congregation is spotted. Stalwarts of the Indian film industry including director Satyajit Ray, and producers AV Meiyappan and B Nagi Reddy sit together and chat as old friends.

This monochrome photograph is only one of the many powerful images that is part of Madras on Stage, a photo exhibition drawn from The Hindu's vast archives at the newspaper's headquarters on Anna Salai from August 14 to September 10.

Part of The Hindu's annual Made of Chennai campaign, the exhibit,

now in its fourth year, is a staple part of the exercise, where guests from the city are invited to the campus of the legendary 87-year-old Art Deco office building, and sift through photo prints collected over generations.

Bringing together decades of photojournalism, the exhibition traces Chennai's cultural life through performances, conversations, festivals, and everyday gatherings. The exhibition marks the beginning of month-long celebrations for Chennai's 387th year.

"All these years, we looked at performers on stage. This time, we wanted to look beyond the stage, at how Chennai's beaches, parks, and other public spaces also became places for performances, gatherings and cultural exchange. It's about the many ways culture unfolded across

the city," says Thirupurasundari Sevel, who put the exhibit together with the help of The Hindu's library team.

But Madras on Stage is only a sliver of what the archives holds. With more than 25 lakh photographs spanning decades, every exhibition is shaped as much by what is left out as what makes it onto the gallery walls. "Every time we begin looking, we discover photographs we didn't know existed," she says, adding that the attempt has been to pick pictures that are often never been seen before, and bring together an unexpected group of people from different walks of life.

Madras on Stage is one of several events marking Chennai's 387th birthday under the Made of Chennai banner. Among the annual highlights is Moonlight Cinema, where classic Tamil films are screened against the backdrop of the Bay of Bengal. This year on

August 16, Kamal Hassan's 2022 hit film *Vikram* will be screened along with *Theri*, starring actor-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay, the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu.

The Made of Chennai reader engagement contests, a series of quizzes, puts the readers' knowledge of the city to the test. The first, a trivia quiz, runs from August 11 to 20 and covers Chennai's cultural heritage, arts, traditions, people and places that have shaped the city. From August 21 to September 10, the photo quiz will take participants back in time, challenging them to identify some of Chennai's significant milestone moments.

For a glimpse into Chennai's early years, head to Royapuram railway station, the city's first, on August 23. The event will take visitors through the historic station with a photo walk and discussions led by historian Thirupurasundari, offering a closer look at the building, its history, and the stories surrounding one of Chennai's oldest surviving railway landmarks.

For those looking to celebrate more actively, the Made of Chennai run returns this year on August 23, in both 5k and 10k categories. Participants will run through Besant Nagar through Aavin junction, Olcott Memorial Higher Secondary School, Third Avenue, and Third Main Road, among other scenic

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Celebrating the city Images from the previous edition of Made of Chennai. B JOTHI RAMALINGAM, AKHILA EASWARAN, AND VELANKANNI RAJ B

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“It’s been incredibly nostalgic to return to Kodaikanal International School after 17 years of graduating,” says Taira Malaney, alumna and documentary film maker from Goa. Kodaikanal International School (KIS), one of the earliest IB schools in Asia, has occupied a distinctive place in the Palani Hills as an institution that has shaped generations of students from India and across the world.

This year, as it completes 125 years, celebrations have begun with a host of events. Established in 1901 as Highclerc School under the leadership of Margaret Eddy, the institution began with a practical need: an English-medium residential school where children of missionary families working across South India could study in the pleasant weather of the hills.

In the 1900s when Margaret travelled to India to visit her son Sherwood, who worked as a missionary in Batlagundu, she saw

the hills taught us

As the Kodaikanal International School completes 125 years, we return with its alumni to a campus where forests were classrooms and lessons extended well beyond the school gates

that children of missionaries suffered from tropical illnesses and lacked a proper local school. However, over the decades, the school’s vision expanded to empowering young people from diverse backgrounds. “Kodaikanal is

not simply where KIS happens to be located; it is part of our identity,” says Keith Ribeiro, director, Admissions and Advancement, adding that the Western Ghats provide an extraordinary living laboratory.



Empowering young minds By building resilience, independence, teamwork and stewardship. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

“Hiking, camping, field studies, environmental research, outdoor sport and service have taught generations of students resilience, independence, teamwork and stewardship. Our 135-acre Poondi wilderness campus expands that learning even further,” says Keith.

Looking back
In 1976, it became the first school in India to offer the International Baccalaureate Diploma Programme. Taira returns to the campus to screen her award-winning documentary *The Turtle Walker* as part of a nationwide campaign to take the film to educational institutions, with KIS being the first stop in this initiative.

“As I walk through the campus, I am flooded with memories of my time here, and am grateful to have studied at the oldest IB school in our country, a space where I always felt nurtured and safe to learn, explore and create,” she says adding that her connection with Nature began here. Keith reiterates that Nature is a

teacher, a classroom, and a responsibility. Increasingly, however, the environment is teaching something more urgent. “The Palani Hills are ecologically fragile, and issues such as biodiversity loss, waste, water, land use and climate change are no longer abstract classroom topics. Students engage with biodiversity conservation, regenerative agriculture, waste management and climate action alongside researchers and local communities,” he explains.

The way students learn
Today, learning at KIS can happen in a classroom, laboratory, forest trail, residence, music room, service project or through an encounter with someone from another culture. “Modernise the tools without losing the purpose,” says Keith, describing what he sees as the institution’s enduring approach to change. Alumna, author, musician, and journalist Zac O’Yeah, who conducted a three-day creative writing workshop with the students,

History gets hands-on

From craft walks and street games to concerts, celebrate Puducherry’s living heritage from August 18 to 30

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The Pondicherry Heritage Festival is back for its 12th year, bringing together music, crafts, traditional games and community experiences under the theme Heritage of Education.

Running from August 18 to 30, this year’s festival explores education beyond classrooms, looking at how culture, arts, Nature, and spirituality shape generations.

Among the highlights this year is a concert by Carnatic vocalist TM Krishna on August 20, from 7pm onwards, at Gratitude Heritage, 52 Rue Romain Rolland. Krishna will be accompanied by Praveen Sparsh on the mridangam, Sayee Rakshith on violin and N Gurupasad on ghatam.

“Pondicherry has a great heritage of education, starting from the ancient land of Bahour, which is one of the oldest parts of Pondicherry. There was a Sanskrit university or school there over 1,000



Arts and crafts School children taking part in a street play organised as part of the Pondicherry Heritage Festival. ss KUMAR

years ago. Subsequently, there has been significant development in education across its various aspects. So, when we celebrate anything, we always take an integral approach. Education is not just about schools, colleges and traditional forms of learning; it exists in so many different ways. All the events we are doing this year are, in some way, linked to education,” says Sunaina Mandeem, member, PondyCan and co-founder, People for Pondicherry’s Heritage.

For those interested in

traditional crafts, the festival’s Craft Walk on August 29, offers an opportunity to explore village craft units around Kottakarai and Alankuppam, near Auroville. Scheduled from 2.30pm to 5.30pm, the walk offers a closer look at local craft-making traditions and people who keep the skills alive.

The festival takes heritage out onto the streets with Veedhi Vilayattu, a street play event on August 30. Held from 8.30am to noon on Kamatchi Amman Koil Street, between MG Road

and Mission Street, the event will revive traditional games and activities in a safe, communal setting. Families are encouraged to bring along children, friends and neighbours, as well as a traditional game, activity or even a bedtime story shared by their grandparents.

The festival’s focus on education is rooted in Puducherry’s long history as a centre of learning, with institutions such as the Pensionnat des Jeunes Filles, Lycée Français, Petit Séminaire, Calvé College and VOC School forming part of its educational heritage.

The Pondicherry Heritage Festival is a volunteer-led initiative organised by People for Pondicherry’s Heritage, INTACH Pondicherry and PondyCAN, fostering pride in Puducherry’s identity and bringing residents, experts, historians and visitors together to celebrate its shared heritage.

The Pondicherry Heritage Festival will be on from August 18 to 30. For more information on programmes, follow @pondicherryheritage on Instagram.

Elsa Sunny
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“Boat number three!” yells Roshni Anand, executive secretary, Royal Madras Yacht Club (RMYC). I line up in front of the club with five other people, all slipping on green life jackets. Dark clouds loom in the sky, and a strong downpour has just paused. My first sailing experience, which is almost cancelled because of the weather, finally begins. It feels like a stroke of beginner’s luck.

Nested in Chennai Port Harbour, in the heart of the city, the Royal Madras Yacht Club was established in 1911 and is popularly known as the first sailing club in South India.

A small boat takes us out into the waters, where a J/80 sailboat – sturdy and French-built – awaits, with its mighty sail bearing the letters ‘RMYC’. There, Captain Vivek Shanbag helps us aboard. An airline pilot by profession and a sailor by passion, Vivek, the secretary of RMYC, has been sailing with the club for the past 20 years.

“The front of the boat is called 12 o’clock, the back is 6 o’clock, and the right and left are 3 and 9 o’clock,” Vivek begins, giving us directions and introducing us to the vocabulary of sailing. “The left side is called the port side, while the right is called the starboard side,” he adds.

We are participating in RMYC’s leisure sailing programme, where more than 50 people have gathered to experience sailing. “Children as young as seven to adults up to the age of 93 have sailed with us. People enjoy being out at sea,” says Vivek.

Over the past year, the club launched moonlight sailing, says Ram Kumar, a member of RMYC for more than 40 years.



Ocean chronicles Members of RMYC sailing a J/80 sailboat. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The sea, at 12 o’clock

Members from the 115-year-old Royal Madras Yacht Club take to the Bay of Bengal for leisure, competition and moonlight sails

“We start sailing at 5.30pm and wind up by 7.30pm. On a clear night you get to see the moon and stars. That is a very lovely experience,” he adds.

The club also promotes competitive sailing, where children are trained to compete at State, national, and international-level competitions along with offshore sailing. Dheer Singh, a member who

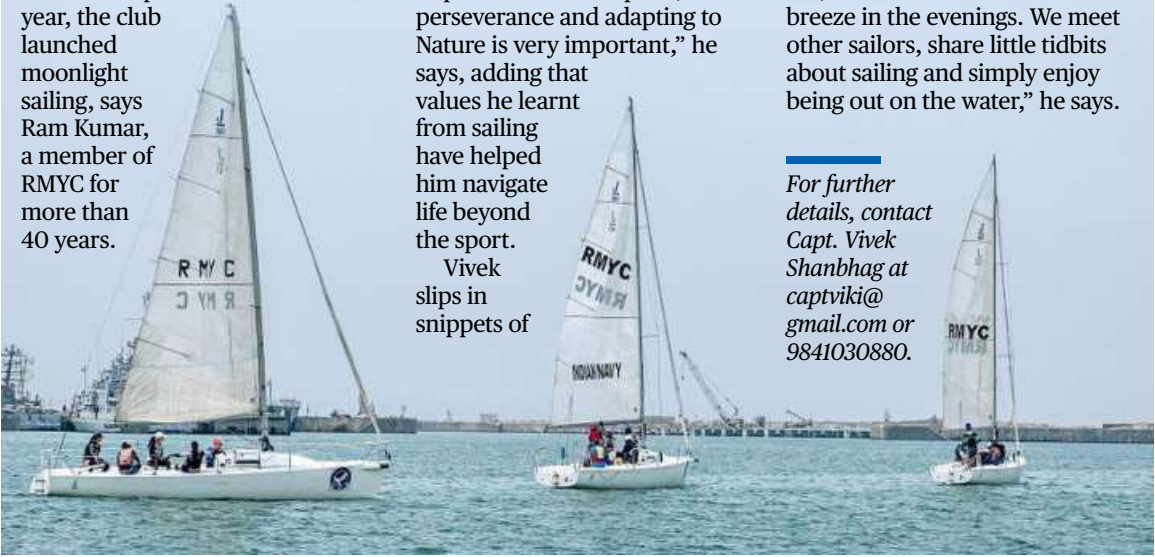
is going to represent India for BRICS International Sailing Championship in Belarus at the end of the month, says he started sailing when he was nine years old. “We don’t have a field like other sports. The ocean is our field and it is unpredictable. Discipline, perseverance and adapting to Nature is very important,” he says, adding that values he learnt from sailing have helped him navigate life beyond the sport.

Vivek slips in snippets of

Chennai’s history during the sail. He says the club, which was founded as the Madras Sailing Club, was later accorded a ‘Royal’ status by King George V, becoming the Royal Madras Yacht Club. He throws in a bit of trivia: During First World War, the German cruiser Emden shelled the city near Madras Port. While its main target was the oil tanks at the harbour, several shells landed on buildings here including the Madras Sailing Club.

Our trip ends as our small boat carried us back to the club. Onshore, music plays loudly as members gather over refreshments. For Ram Kumar, a member of the club, evenings like these are what makes sailing special. “Especially in Chennai, given the humid conditions, it is very pleasant to sail in the open sea, with the fresh air and a nice breeze in the evenings. We meet other sailors, share little tidbits about sailing and simply enjoy being out on the water,” he says.

For further details, contact Capt. Vivek Shanbhag at captviki@gmail.com or 9841030880.



METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #66
(Set by Doppelganger)

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1 Whiz (7)

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8 Corrupt (7)

9 Improvise (2-3)

10 Mustard family plant (5)

11 Tiring (7)

12 Adios (3-3)

14 Atone (6)

17 Balanced (7)

19 Relating to a citizen (5)

22 Great brilliance (5)

23 Defeat (7)

24 Rest area (3-2)

25 Keep up (7)

Down

1 Devastation (5)

2 Offering to religious organization (5)

3 Rumour (7)

4 One score (6)

5 Tartan (5)

6 Set free (7)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Solution No. 66

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PHOTOS: JOHAN SATYADAS, B VELANKKANI RAJ, AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Amaravathi

At Amaravathi, the second generation, represented by Nivruti Reddy, is a constant presence at the flagship outlet on Cathedral Road, even as she manages her time across other establishments. When I walk into Amaravathi at lunch time, the place is packed. “The sourcing of raw materials and preparation are carefully coordinated, a process refined over the years. Every ingredient is made in-house,” she says, joining me at the table. Amaravathi is best known for its meals, popular both during lunch and dinner. “Our in-house preparations like rotu pachchadi and ragi ball with Andhra fish pulusu are in constant demand,” says Ramesh, the manager. As the banana leaf is filled with chutneys, pickles, and thokkus, the ragi ball catches my eye. Dipped in the spicy fish curry, it tastes divine. I wonder if the health conscious diner still indulges in Andhra cuisine. Alongside the traditional vegetarian meals, complimented by non-vegetarian side dishes, the biryani platter is a popular choice. It features four small portions each of mutton, chicken, and prawn biryani along with white rice. Diners can also opt for three non-vegetarian gravies as add-ons. Not to be missed are the highlights – Andhra chicken and vanjaram fry. The meal ends with a delicious tumbler of South Indian coffee. A fitting end. *Mylapore. Phone: 9500020011.*

Velidis

After several years as an advertising professional, V Veeraiah chose to follow a passion and enter the food industry, taking on the responsibility of managing the kitchen of a leading club in the city. “That the speciality of the club was Andhra cuisine was coincidental, given my family background as chilli growers from Chirala,” says Veeraiah. When an opportunity arose, he decided toopen Velidis (named after his family) in the busy Ramapuram locality in 2004. “That’s when I realised that the area was already crowded with many Andhra messes serving meals for much below ₹100 a plate,” recalls Veeraiah. Undeterred, he curated a distinctive menu of Andhra dishes. Velidis special chicken biryani and Velidis joint chicken biryani, both topped with Megana chicken dry or Aalfa chicken dry are the most popular dishes. “That we source the best quality Guntur chillies and use only basmati rice for our biryanis, has ensured the top quality in taste. For our seafood dishes, fresh vanjaram and prawns are procured daily and we do not refrigerate them for the next day,” informs Veeraiah. The biryani has a distinct flavour and I am told the dishes are cooked on coal, as are their tandoori preparations. The success of Velidis at Ramapuram has encouraged him to open another outlet in Pallavaram. *Manapakkam. Phone: 9380938513.*

plate clean

From heritage eateries in Sowcarpet to popular dining spots across the city, Chennai’s Andhra restaurants serve unforgettable meals that keep diners coming back for more

Nikhil Raghavan

Variety is literally the spice of life in Andhra cuisine. The region is traditionally known as the ‘spice heartland of India’, and there is no getting away from the range of fiery masalas – like Guntur Sannam chillies, gongura leaves, turmeric, ginger, and mustard seeds – that add so much ‘oomph’ to Andhra dishes. Chennai has always played host to a large Telugu community from different walks of life, making Andhra cuisine immensely popular in the city for its distinctive spices and traditional recipes. Their hospitality comes alive at some of the city’s iconic eateries. Here is our pick.



The National Lodge

Third-generation family member Satyanarayana Deepak says, “When my grandfather, K Ethiraj established the National Lodge in 1952, it functioned as a lodging house and a restaurant. Businessmen from across the Madras Presidency would come to Sowcarpet for trade. For many, especially those from Andhra, this became the preferred place to stay and enjoy homely Andhra food.” Today, Deepak, along with his brother, Satyanarayana Dwarak and son, Vidhant, manage the Sowcarpet and Mount Road outlets, serving nearly 120 diners at a time. As with most traditional Andhra cuisine, the meals are the highlight of the day. Once the rice is served, the National special parupu podi arrives, and either raw tamarind chutney, gongura pachadi or tomato thokku are served in turns. The piece-de-resistance arrives with the second serving of rice – a delicious bowl of vada sambar. The leaf is further adorned with poriyal, pickle, pachadi, rasam, buttermilk and finally, curd with sugar! It is evidently, the quality that has sustained them for as long. *Sowcarpet and Anna Salai, Phone: 9840161919.*

New Andhra Meals Hotel

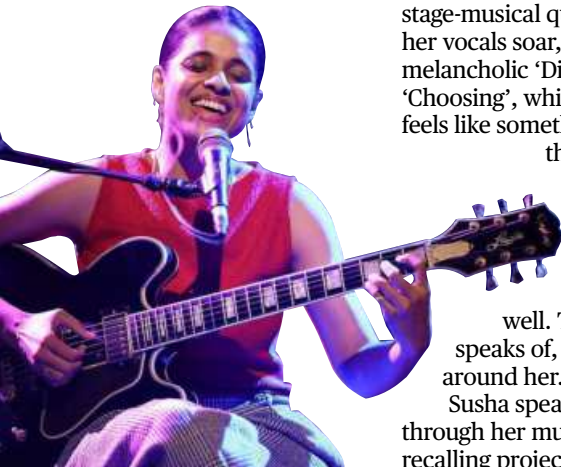
Towards the eastern end of Pondy Bazaar, Chennai’s shopping hub, stands the New Andhra Meals Hotel, drawing a steady stream of patrons as well as first time diners who arrive on recommendation. “We serve the traditional vegetarian meals on the banana leaf, with the option of non-vegetarian side dishes. If requested we also serve non-vegetarian gravies,” says P Balakrishna, the owner, who is known to be at the outlets early each day. The Pondy Bazaar branch has been managed by Venkatesan since 2001, while Balakrishna’s close associate Prakash oversees operations here as well as at the newer Valasaravakkam outlet. The highlight of their Andhra meals is the generously sized vanjaram fry, along with succulent Andhra prawns, with the fish sourced from a regular vendor in Zam Bazaar. With these two items on the leaf, everything else takes a back seat, though the rest of the fare holds its own. The Nellore rice which is specially sourced, compliments dishes such as karakozhambu, sambar, rasam and morekolambu. “Guntur chicken, Hyderabad chicken 65, mutton and gongura are prepared by using our own spices,” says Balakrishna, adding that their mutton, chicken and egg biryanis are equally popular. I am told that very little has changed in their menu over the years. “It has always been selectively curated and only the most sought-after dishes are featured,” says Balakrishna. “However, due to popular demand we have introduced tandoori chicken, chapathi and parotta.” *T Nagar, Phone: 7708099915.*



Chennai-based musician Susha on her first full-fledged independent music album *Love Language*, collaborating with friends, and why her music now feels like an act of self-care

S Poorvaia

Susha describes her first independent full-fledged music album, *Love Language*, as an act of self-care. “All the songs in this album are about love and a spectrum of how it manifests through lived experiences. But for me, just deciding that I was going to take this big scary step, of taking two years to put in my time, money and focus into this journey felt like an act of love towards myself,” she smiles. When we meet to discuss *Love Language*, we run through, of course, all what the Chennai-based singer has done with music, over the years. “I went through some old videos and found one of me signing the invocation at my mother’s (Carnatic singer Lakshmi Rangarajan) album launch,” she says.



Having trained in Carnatic music from a young age, Susha went on to complete a Master’s degree in Jazz Performance and Composition at the University of Toronto. Over the years, she has experimented across genres and formats, from playback singing, including the lilting ‘Agam Thaana’ from *Sillu Karupatti*, to composing the music for *Achcham Madam Naanam Payirppu*, a film. Her collaborations have also included contemporary Indian bands Yodhaka and Poorvaa, and, more recently, Band Cooum, a music collective focussed on folk, Carnatic, independent, and electronic music. Across the 12 songs in *Love Language*, these musical influences, ranging from jazz to Tamil melodies and even folk, are hard to miss. Susha says that she was certain she did not want to box the album or assign it a specific genre. If ‘Be Still’ has an almost stage-musical quality to it where her vocals soar, there is the more melancholic ‘Different’, and ‘Choosing’, which is upbeat and feels like something wafting out of the speakers of a jazz club. While predominantly in English, the album has three Tamil songs as well. The love that she speaks of, manifests itself around her. Susha speaks of collaborations through her music career fondly, recalling projects with Pradeep

Kumar and Sean Roldan. “I feel like I am friends with every musician I have ever wanted to play with, so I have definitely spoilt for choice working on *Love Language*,” she laughs. The musicians include percussionist and long-time friend and collaborator Praveen Sparsh, violinist Sayee Rakshith, Rithu Vysakh (who she describes as a ‘strings wizard’), and New York-based bassist Eduardo Belo. The album release was marked by a live performance at Medai last week in Chennai. “It is a very exciting time now to be an artiste and put out independent music; I absolutely love Dhee’s music for instance, and am excited about MS Krsna’s new album as well,” says Susha. We go back to the beginning of her music journey, with Carnatic music and Susha acknowledges how the extensive training which spanned over two decades has helped her explore, and find diverse music to learn and dabble in. “Every song in *Love Language* felt like a triumph to myself. And while the album came together over two years, there are songs here that I had written years ago; every listen now feels like a memory box, something close, personal and special for my first full-fledged independent project,” she adds. *Love Language is out on Spotify. Follow Susha’s work on Instagram @sushasings*

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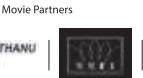
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Vijay Sethupathi's next
Tamil star Vijay Sethupathi and filmmaker Balaji Tharaneetharan are reuniting for an upcoming film titled *Baththa*. Presented by Atlee and produced by Priya Atlee, the film is set to release in theatres on October 1. The film stars Lijomol Jose as the female lead. Other details are under wraps. With music scored by Sai Abhyankkar, *Baththa* has cinematography by Selva Kumar SK and editing by R Kalaivanan. Murad Khetani, Priya Atlee, Alok Jain, and Ajit Andhara produce the film under their A Cine1 Studios and A For Apple Studios banner. Notably, Vijay and Balaji previously teamed up for *Naduvula Konjam Pakkatha Kaanom* and *Seethakaathi*.



Rudhra unveiled
Mahesh Babu's first look as Rudhra from SS Rajamouli's pan-Indian epic *Varanasi* has been unveiled. The newly released images show Mahesh sporting a beard and casual outdoor gear. One of the visuals places the character amid the African wilderness, with zebras and giraffes visible in the background. Another shows the actor relaxing on a bamboo raft or cot surrounded by dense greenery. *Varanasi* also stars Priyanka Chopra and Prithviraj Sukumaran. The film, with music by Oscar-winning composer MM Keeravani, is scheduled for a release on April 7, 2027.

What's in a number Mamitha Baiju and Suriya in a still from *Vishwanath & Sons*; (inset) Venky Atluri. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



I've admired Suriya sir since Kaakha Kaakha and I'm happy I could bring him back to a breezy family drama after more than 10 years

VENKY ATLURI
Writer-director

everyone, especially Gen Z. They don't want to be lectured to, but I still try to weave in life's lessons in my own way."

What Gen Z thinks

Venky was curious to know whether women in their early 20s viewed age gaps as a concern in relationships. "I spoke to several women in that age group and was surprised by how casually they dismissed it," he says.

"It's a generational shift from how an '80s kid like me thinks. For Gen Z, compatibility matters more than age."

Asked if he had Suriya in mind while writing the script, Venky smiles. "I never keep my hopes high while writing because I still fear rejection. I've admired Suriya sir since *Kaakha Kaakha* and *Ghajini*, and I've always felt he thinks ahead of his time. He believed in this story because it offered a pleasant change after the mass entertainer *Karuppu*. I'm happy I could bring him back to a breezy family drama after 13 or 14 years."

Venky credits Suriya for creating a comfortable atmosphere on set and praises Mamitha Baiju for holding her own alongside senior actors like Suriya and Radhika. "The casting worked beautifully, and audiences will see that chemistry on screen."

With *Vishwanath & Sons* set for a bilingual release on August 14, Venky describes the film as a calculated risk at a time when action entertainers continue to dominate the post-pandemic box office.

"But we've also seen clutter-breakers succeed in both Telugu and Tamil cinema," he says. "We were clear about our budget. We spent what the story demanded because we had a big star."

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An unlikely match

Venky Atluri discusses *Vishwanath & Sons*, Suriya's return to romance, and portraying an age-gap relationship with sensitivity

In mid-July, as director Venky Atluri was adding the finishing touches on his upcoming Tamil-Telugu film *Vishwanath & Sons*, another milestone arrived. The 72nd National Film Awards recognised him with the Best Screenplay (Dialogue Writer) award for his 2024 Telugu film *Lucky Baskhar*.

When the announcement was made, Venky admitted the news took its time to sink in. He describes the honour as a validation of his efforts. "It also makes me more responsible," he says.

"People will now pay closer attention to how I write and portray my characters."

Speaking at Sithara Entertainments' office in Hyderabad, Venky reflects on *Vishwanath & Sons*, which explores an age-gap relationship, and how it will resonate with family audiences, especially Gen Z.

Venky counts legendary filmmakers K Balachander,

Bharathiraja, Mani Ratnam and Trivikram Srinivas among his biggest influences. "In the 1970s and '80s, cinematic writing was still evolving from theatre and literary adaptations," he says.

"For the first time, I realised that less is more in Mani sir's films. The conversations were simple, with the focus firmly on human emotions. In Telugu cinema, Trivikram sir moved away from heavy, dialogue-driven writing and embraced simplicity. *Nuvvu Naaku Nachav* especially

made me want to write and direct."

Venky made his directorial debut with *Tholi Prema* in 2018. Although he followed it with two more romances before branching into other genres, audiences continued to associate him with love stories. "People kept asking me when I'd make another film like *Tholi Prema*," he says.

"The first draft of that film was written in 2013. It would be difficult for me to write that kind of romance today. But I had this

idea of an age-gap relationship and wanted to tell a more mature love story. I just started writing, one page at a time."

May-December romances
Vishwanath & Sons stars Suriya as a 40-year-old man and Mamitha Baiju as a 20-year-old woman. "I wondered how their equation would evolve," says Venky. "How do I portray it without making it seem inappropriate?"

May-December romances are not new to Indian cinema. *Apoorva Raagangal*, *Mudhal Mariyadhai*, *Lamhe*, *Nishabd*, *Cheeni Kum* and *Dil Chahta Hai* have all explored the theme. Venky counts *Lamhe* among his favourites.

"Whenever I explore a genre, I revisit films in that space, not to imitate them, but to understand how certain situations were handled and to ensure I'm bringing something fresh."

Balancing humour, entertainment and sensitivity, he admits, was the biggest challenge. "It's complicated to keep a story simple and simple to complicate one," he says. "I want the drama in my films to connect with



Can Crazy Mohan's lines find new life when the audience is sitting just a few feet away? *Chamber of Humour* intends to find out

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Inside a dark room at Luz's MdnD performance space, the laughs are on. As the Tamil theatre group Crazy Creations stage their evergreen comedy play, *Marriage Made in Saloon*, the first row erupts in laughter at a clever wordplay that its protagonist, 'Maadhu' Balaji, has just cracked.

This could be a Sunday evening at any of the leading sabhas in Chennai. Except it is not.

Here, the audience is so close to the performer that – in Balaji's own witty words – "*kai romba neetina, yaara mooka kuthiduvan*" (If I stretch my hand, I'll poke the nose of the person in the first row").

With about 50 people watching, seated close to each



other and to the performers, late playwright Crazy Mohan's Tamil comedies are not only finding new audiences, but also a home in intimate spaces in the city. Through *Chamber of Humour*, Crazy Mohan's brother and actor, Madhu Balaji, wants to take Tamil theatre to smaller sets of audiences.

"A friend of mine (RK Ramanathan, Carnatic vocalist

Ramnad Krishnan's son) recently spoke about how 'Chamber of Music' would happen in the past," recalls Balaji, "Leading Carnatic vocalists would perform at someone's house to select audiences. This would be followed by a discussion on the songlist and the ragas featured in it. I thought it was a fantastic idea that Tamil theatre could borrow."

Helping him implement the idea was the fact that most of Crazy Mohan-driven plays relied primarily on dialogue and wordplay. "Our productions don't have elaborate backdrops or lighting. It is like a duet between the artiste and the audience."

Up close and personal
It helps that the artiste is just a few feet from you, feels Kalyanasundaram K of MdnD, which will be hosting a line-up of plays for the next few months and during the season of Margazhi. "You almost relate to the person speaking on stage. It is the equivalent of staging a play in your hall."

Apart from relatability, such a

Carrying the legacy A still from 'Maadhu' Balaji's *Chamber of Humour*; (below) Balaji with Crazy Mohan. SHIVARAJ S AND K GANESAN

setting also allows you to let your guard down. Explains Balaji, "Before the play, we tell audiences to have no inhibitions. Our aim is to see them laugh heartily, which in turn spurs us on to deliver our lines better."

Slowly, *Chamber of Humour* will be spreading to other areas in Chennai; Balaji is currently scouting for small venues in areas like Shenoy Nagar and Ambattur, where the same troupe once staged a lot of their plays. "We are ready even if a terrace is available!"

Beyond this concept, Balaji is also looking at ways to bring some of Mohan's scripts to life. "There are two that stand out for me – one called *Madhu MLA* and another titled *Son of Superman*. Apart from that, he has also penned many dialogues or scenes that do not belong to a particular play. We wish to stitch them together to form a storyline."

Helping him in this pursuit to carry the comedian's legacy forward is popular actor Kamal Haasan. "He (Kamal) is a big supporter and has taken on a mentoring role," states Balaji, "He tells us that just like there is patronage for his comedy films like *Michael Madana Kama Rajan* and *Avvai Shanmukhi*, there will be audiences for the plays too. Upon his advice, we are also roping in several youngsters, even for key roles. That way, we hope to carry Crazy Mohan's legacy to the next generation."

Chamber of Humour will next be staged on September 13 (Madhil Mel Maadhu at 4pm, followed by Chocolate Krishna at 6.45pm) at MdnD performance centre, Luz Church Road.

Moment to shine

***Shared Spaces*, a docu-series hosted by Bahar Dutt, explores the complexity of human-impacted wild spaces**

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In India, wildlife exists in a sea of humanity. Still, their stories are often told as if human beings are outside Nature, says award-winning environmental journalist Bahar Dutt, who believes this worldview stems from a Western cultural lens. It is this narrative that *Shared Spaces*, a six-part documentary series on Animal Planet, hosted by Bahar and filmed by her partner, Emmy-nominated wildlife filmmaker Vijay Bedi, deliberately subverts.

"We tried to step away from the typical natural history format: blue-chip films being produced across the globe, which showcase animals living in beautiful forests," says Vijay about the series, which is instead "told in the larger context of human-impacted wild spaces". From looking at community conservation initiatives in the Northeast and a controversial dog versus wildlife conflict unfurling in the grasslands of Maharashtra, to ingenious elephant management methods in West Bengal, the consequences of wolves and dogs breeding and broader philosophical questions about whether infrastructure development and ecological sanctity can go hand in hand, each of the films forces viewers to, in Vijay's words, "think of shared spaces in a new way."

While these films do, of course, shed light on this complex issue, they do not lose sight of

engrossing behaviours displayed by animals – a pair of salamanders courting and mating, cut to ballet music, or elephants frolicking in water on an island – and the humans they interact with, whether it is the concoction of a strange, smelly soup to ward off elephants or the way hunting cages are being transformed into nesting cages for hill mynahs in Meghalaya. "The idea was to make these natural history sequences interesting to audiences so they can understand and relate to the species," he says, something Bahar concurs with. "We wanted these films to bring back the feeling of awe and wonder." They also hope the series will help draw more attention to the idea of shared spaces, given that humans have lived with animals for centuries. "For me, it is also about changing the language of conservation," says Bahar, pointing out that conservation biology, in its vocabulary, is often extremely exclusionary.

The hope now is for these films to eventually reach the people who actually live in these shared spaces and are most affected by the wildlife that also calls them home. "The fact that Animal Planet has come on board and is making it in regional

languages makes it easier for us," says Bahar, who believes that the next step is "small, non-commercial screenings for these communities we stayed with. We are going back."

India: Epic Wild Stories is being telecast on Animal Planet and will be available on the Discovery+ platform.

